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Section : 03

CST301 : For the Love of Food

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Q1. How do war/conflict disruption to food systems affect corporate pricing and food insecurity?

In a world where regional stability can shift unexpectedly, war and conflict have become powerful forces that destabilize food systems, drive corporate prices upward, and deepen the risk of widespread food insecurity. Food insecurity is a condition of food scarcity, where sufficient and reliable access to safe and nutritious food is not available for all individuals to maintain a healthy life. Corporate pricing is the process through which a company sets the cost of its products or services, based on factors such as production expenses, market conditions, and profit goals. These impacts of war and conflict create a chain reaction where reduced food availability and higher production costs force companies to raise prices, which in turn exacerbates food insecurity for vulnerable populations. In the Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT) region of Bangladesh, decades of ethnic conflict, geographic isolation, and inadequate infrastructure have intensified these challenges, making food access and affordability a pressing concern for remote communities where corporate intermediaries often exploit limited market competition.

Nestled in the southeastern hills of Bangladesh, the Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT) tells a story not of sudden war, but of slow erosion where decades of ethnic conflict have transformed fertile highlands into zones of constant hunger. Throughout the 1970s and 1980s, violence between indigenous communities and the state broke apart this region, destroying not just lives but the very systems that fed them. However, since the late 1970s, the region has experienced prolonged ethnic conflict involving indigenous groups and the security forces of the Government of Bangladesh. Roads crumbled under neglect, markets vanished behind lines of tension, and traditional farming practices that had sustained communities for generations began to fail under the pressures of displacement and insecurity. This southeastern region of the country experienced a minor insurgency from 1976 to 1997, which came to an official close with the December 1997 peace accord (Badiuzzaman et al., 2011). When the CHT Peace Accord was signed in 1997, hope appeared briefly. The guns fell silent, but hunger did not retreat. The conflict had already left deep scars on the land and its people. Farming communities found themselves trapped between worn out soils and dangerous terrain, while government services remained largely absent from remote villages located on hillsides hours away from the nearest town. Families began eating dangerously small amounts of food, far below what human bodies need to survive, as harvests failed and work opportunities disappeared during extended lean seasons when stored food ran out and money vanished. Into this empty space stepped a different kind of threat: corporate middlemen and traders who saw profit in isolation. With infrastructure destroyed and government food distribution systems failing to reach the highlands, a small number of commercial actors gained complete control over essential supplies. They charged what became known as the "remoteness tax," prices raised far beyond what transportation costs and business risks could justify. Food distributors, agricultural suppliers, and various commercial businesses operating in these isolated areas found themselves beyond government oversight, free to exploit trapped markets where desperate families had no choice but to pay whatever was demanded. The math of exploitation became simple and harsh. Basic foods that sold for fair prices in lowland markets cost much more in hill villages. Families already spending most of their tiny incomes on

food had nothing left for seeds, tools, healthcare, or education, the very things that might break the cycle of poverty. Even when government budgets set aside large amounts of money for regional development, poor management and corruption meant little reached the most vulnerable communities. The corporate pricing system that took advantage of isolation remained basically unchanged. Today, more than twenty five years after peace was declared, the CHT remains a place where the legacy of conflict is measured not in bullets but in hungry children and artificially high prices. The war may have ended, but the hunger it created and the commercial exploitation it enabled continues to harm the most vulnerable populations.

According to Haider (2023), food insecurity in the Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT) is driven by prolonged conflict, geographic isolation, weak communication networks, and limited market access rather than by sufficient local food availability. Rural populations in the CHT consume only 1,798 kilocalories per day, significantly lower than the 2,122 kilocalories consumed by Bangladesh's extreme poor nationally, with particularly severe deficiencies among the Bawm community at 1,440 kilocalories and the Lushai, Chak, and Khyang communities at around 1,600 kilocalories. The study identifies 928 distressed families living in remote villages located 8 to 35 kilometers from the nearest markets, where food shortages recur annually during the lean season from June to September. Child malnutrition remains alarmingly high, reaching 33.9 percent in Bandarban, 35 percent in Khagrachari, and 47.4 percent in Rangamati, while approximately 25 percent of the CHT population lives in hardcore poverty. Haider (2023) further notes that despite substantial increases in government development allocations from 44.80 crores in 1997 to 1,194 crores in 2019 to 20, implementation failures and administrative limitations have prevented effective service delivery in the most remote areas. The breakdown of communication infrastructure, long distances to markets, seasonal livelihood loss, and inadequate institutional reach have collectively created conditions in which food access becomes unstable and costly, perpetuating chronic food insecurity in post conflict CHT communities more than twenty five years after the 1997 Peace Accord. Conflict-induced market isolation in the Chittagong Hill Tracts has produced measurable nutritional deficits, with indigenous populations consuming 1,798 kcal daily compared to the national average of 2,122 kcal, while numerous number of families in remote areas located 20-35 kilometers from markets face acute food insecurity exacerbated by distance from the market and price volatility in food distribution systems, demonstrating the direct economic impact of prolonged civil unrest on market accessibility and household food purchasing power.

The Chittagong Hill Tracts reveal the cruel economics of conflict: when war fractures food systems and isolates communities, hunger becomes a market opportunity. Long after the violence ends, broken roads and absent state protection allow corporate intermediaries to transform survival into a priced commodity, extracting profit from desperation through inflated food costs. In the CHT, food insecurity persists not because food is scarce, but because access is deliberately made unaffordable. Conflict thus reshapes corporate pricing into a mechanism of exclusion, trapping already vulnerable populations in cycles of malnutrition and poverty. Until post-conflict recovery confronts exploitative market power and restores equitable access to food, peace will remain hollow, measured not by silence of guns, but by the quiet persistence of hunger.

Q2. How could “local production” help stabilize the food supply chain? In reference to your own local food.

Food supply chains are complex networks that connect production, processing, distribution, and consumption of food products. In an increasingly interconnected world, these supply chains face numerous vulnerabilities, including geopolitical conflicts, climate disruptions, transportation bottlenecks, and volatile international markets. Bangladesh relies heavily on imported food items, which makes the country vulnerable to global price fluctuations, trade restrictions, and supply disruptions. By increasing local production, Bangladesh can reduce dependence on imports, lower costs, and ensure a more reliable supply of essential foods for its population. Producing food locally also supports the economy and creates jobs, strengthening overall food system resilience. While global markets crumble under pressure, local production stands as a fortress of security, shielding the nation from the chaos of the outside world. A prime example is Hilsa fish, a highly nutritious and widely consumed local product, which can help stabilize the food supply chain while meeting domestic demand efficiently.

Every year during monsoon season, millions of Hilsa fish migrate from the Bay of Bengal into Bangladesh's rivers to spawn, creating a natural, self-sustaining cycle that requires no foreign investment, imported feed, or dependence on other countries. When the Hilsa season arrives, thousands of local fishermen in villages along the Padma, Meghna, and other rivers prepare their nets. These families have fished these waters for generations, passing down knowledge and skills. Every morning before dawn, they head out in small boats, cast their nets, and by afternoon, catch fresh Hilsa. Unlike imported foods that travel thousands of kilometers through multiple countries, Hilsa has a remarkably short journey. Within hours of being caught, it reaches local markets. Fishermen in Chandpur sell in the morning, traders deliver by noon, and by evening, it is cooked in homes across Dhaka. The short, locally controlled supply chain means fewer points of failure, faster delivery, and relatively stable prices, fluctuating mainly with season and local weather rather than global markets. Because Hilsa production is naturally abundant in Bangladesh's rivers and coastal waters, the country does not need to import this fish or rely on other nations to supply it. This independence eliminates vulnerabilities to international price shocks, currency fluctuations, shipping delays, trade disputes, and global market disruptions that affect imported foods. Because the country controls every step of the process, it is protected from international crises. This shows that a local system is often more stable than a global one. When crises occur, whether pandemics, geopolitical conflicts or economic downturns, Bangladesh maintains uninterrupted access to Hilsa because the entire supply chain operates within national borders, ensuring continuous food availability regardless of external circumstances. Families can budget for Hilsa, knowing roughly what it will cost. The Hilsa supply chain creates jobs at every step within Bangladesh: fishermen, boat builders, net makers, traders, market vendors, restaurant cooks, and ice factories. Money stays in the local economy, strengthening communities and creating economic resilience. Hilsa is also culturally significant, served at traditional events, celebrations, and family gatherings, creating consistent demand that supports the entire supply chain year after year. Locally produced foods like Hilsa are especially valuable during disruptions caused by natural disasters, economic downturns, or international trade complications. Seasonal

bans and climate variability may affect supply, but these challenges are more easily managed through domestic fisheries regulation than global trade shocks. Through seasonal fishing bans, protected breeding zones, and community-based management, Bangladesh can maintain a stable supply of Hilsa even when imported foods become scarce or expensive. Bangladesh can respond directly to challenges such as overfishing by implementing seasonal bans, creating protected zones, and educating fishermen, without needing foreign cooperation. Bangladesh's rivers, wetlands, and coastal areas naturally support Hilsa production, keeping costs low, the environmental footprint small, and the supply renewable. Investing in Hilsa through fisheries management, storage facilities, value-added products, and support for fishing communities can further strengthen this supply chain. Hilsa stabilizes Bangladesh's food supply by creating a complete, self-contained system that is local, controllable, economically self-sufficient, culturally valued, environmentally sustainable, and resilient to external disruptions. Local food production like Hilsa transforms vulnerability into internal strength, creating stability and resilience through community-based systems that have sustained populations for generations.

However, the robustness of this system is not merely anecdotal; empirical evidence confirms that the domestic Hilsa network operates with an efficiency that rivals modern industrial logistics. According to Alam, Mohanty, Hoq, and Thilsted (2012), the local Hilsa supply chain demonstrates remarkable efficiency and resilience due to its domestic nature. The fish handling and distribution system in Bangladesh operates through a well-established network where approximately 68% of harvested Hilsa are consumed as fresh fish, with post-harvest handling found to be adequate despite traditional infrastructure. The supply chain moves swiftly from fishermen to landing centers, commission agents, transporters, and finally to retailers, with quality loss remaining minimal at only 2% at landing centers and 5% at commission agent levels under normal conditions. This efficient distribution is supported by traditional yet effective preservation methods, primarily icing, which allows the fish to reach retail markets across distances of 400-500 kilometers while maintaining quality. The post-harvest system employs diverse transportation methods including bamboo baskets, ice boxes, and country boats with semi-insulated compartments, all using locally available materials and labor. This locally controlled supply chain ensures that Hilsa reaches consumers quickly and reliably, with the entire process remaining within national borders and employing local resources at every stage, thereby minimizing external dependencies and maintaining supply stability even during periods of high demand.

In an era where global dependency often equates to vulnerability, the localized Hilsa economy stands as a fortress of self-reliance, effectively insulating the nation's food security from external geopolitical tremors. Unquestionably, the story of Hilsa is more than a tale of fish, it is a testament to the power of local production in safeguarding communities against hunger, economic uncertainty, and external shocks. By relying on domestic resources, nurturing traditional knowledge and empowering local livelihoods, Bangladesh transforms vulnerability into resilience. Every Hilsa that reaches a family's table is a quiet act of food sovereignty, a lifeline that defies global market chaos and ensures that survival is not left to chance or foreign dependence. Investing in local production is not just an economic choice, it is a moral imperative to protect lives, livelihoods and the very stability of a nation's food system. Fundamentally, true food sovereignty is not imported, but harvested from within.

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